

NORTH VERSUS South

THE US CIVIL WAR

By 1850, abolitionists (see pp. 172–175) in the Northern US had grown more aggressive in their fight for universal liberty. The serialization of Harriet Beecher Stowe's novel *Uncle Tom's Cabin* in 1851, followed by its edition in book form in two volumes in 1852, inflamed existing opinion by bringing attention to the realities and immorality of slavery. The views of the Southern states, however, starkly contrasted those in the North. South Carolina, followed by the rest of the Southern states, chose to secede from the Union rather than end slavery, sparking a bloody civil war. Fighting began on April 12, 1861, with the bombardment of Fort Sumter by Southern "Confederate" states.

War work

The war was one of the most significant events in US history, and women played an important role on the battlefield, in hospitals, and at home. About 20,000 females on both sides of the conflict became nurses in military hospitals. Dorothea Dix, a white educated woman from Maine, became the Union's "superintendent of female nurses" in 1861 and improved conditions for nurses and wounded soldiers. As the war progressed, formerly enslaved black women volunteered to assist as nurses, cooks, and laundresses. Some of the so-called "camp followers" who followed the troops were married to soldiers; others

▼ Female partisans

This flag designed for the Confederate States of America was allegedly made by the "secessionist ladies" of Washington, D.C., in around 1861. The women presented it to the 6th Virginia Cavalry who carried it during the war.



► Camping out

A Union soldier's wife stands with her husband and children in the 31st Pennsylvania Infantry camp. In addition to taking care of her family, she may have worked as a camp laundress, cook, or nurse.

